ENGAGE

Discussion and Journal Guidelines

How discussions and journals work in this course, and what earns your points.

Discussions are where the real conversation happens in an online course. They're your chance to connect with classmates, share what you actually think, and learn from people whose experiences are different from yours. Journals are the quieter version: a private space to reflect, just between you and your instructor.

Discussions and journals

Discussions	Journals
You post, then reply to classmates. Most discussions have **two deadlines**: one for your first post and one for your replies.	You write one private entry that only your instructor sees. There are no replies, so there's **one deadline**.

Deadlines

Discussion: first post	Discussion replies and journals
Due by **Friday, 11:59 PM CT** of the module week.	Due by **Monday, 11:59 PM CT**, the standard course deadline.

Always check the due date on the discussion or journal itself in Blackboard. Your instructor may adjust dates for a specific activity.

DON'T UNDERESTIMATE THESE

Discussions and journals add up to **12 points, 12% of your course grade**. Each one is worth 1 or 2 points, and the points are listed on each activity in Blackboard.

Skipping a few because they seem small is one of the most common ways students lose points they didn't expect to lose. Show up every module and those points are yours.

What to do in a discussion

1. Read the prompt carefully, and think about how it connects to your own experience or goals.
2. Write your first post by Friday. Aim for about 150 to 200 words, or record a short video or audio response if the discussion allows it.
3. End your post with a real question for your classmates.
4. Come back by Monday and reply thoughtfully to at least two classmates.

Watch for video and audio options. Some discussions invite you to record a response instead of, or along with, writing one. When you see that option, try it. Hearing a classmate's voice adds something to an online conversation that text can't. Your phone or laptop camera is all you need.

Tips for strong participation

Your first post

- Share a brief example or story from your own life.
- Keep paragraphs short. Most people read on a phone.
- Be personal but professional, and proofread before you post.
- End with an open question that invites a real response.

Your replies

- Mention something specific from your classmate's post.
- Add your own perspective, tip, or example. Don't just agree.
- Ask a short follow-up question to keep the conversation going.
- "Great post, I agree!" isn't a reply. Make it count.

How discussions and journals are graded

There's no rubric. Points are for complete, on-time participation in your own words.

Activity	How the points are earned
Discussion	Half the points for a real first post that answers the prompt in your own words, by Friday. Half for real replies to at least two classmates, not one-liners, by Monday.
Journal	All the points for one complete, honest entry that answers the prompt, by Monday.

Your voice and AI

KEEP IT YOURS

Your posts and journal entries should be your own words, ideas, and experiences, not a template, a summary of the prompt, or AI-generated text.

Each discussion and journal has a level of AI use, just like every assignment. Check it before you start. If it doesn't say, or you aren't sure, ask your instructor first. When in doubt, write it yourself.